

Adventures Exploring the Cemeteries of Indiana – Metallicman

 metallicman.com/laoban4site/adventures-exploring-the-cemeteries-of-indiana

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When I lived in Indiana, one of the things that I did was to visit every park in the state. I went and bought a book showing all [25 state parks](#). Then, my wife and I went and visited every one of them. When we were finished, we then went to the local library. We looked at a large map of the county and then visited every cemetery in the county.

It was an “eye opener” and very informative.

Let's talk about this experience

Many of the cemeteries were in isolated areas. We would get to ride on little used back roads that trundled through the rows of soybeans or corn. Then the road would dead end into a tiny space of greenery that typically consisted of some rare trees, a stream or two and some small out-buildings. The park would be lonely and often deserted.

While the grass would be tended to, it was mostly a three week to a one month mowing cycle and tended to be rather lush. There wasn't any kind of landscaping, or care for the weeds and plants that existed besides the tombstones. The headstones themselves were often old, tilted and leaning at precarious angles.



Barrett Cemetery in Indian is typical. It is a small isolated location that often has trees growing in and around the tombstones. No one is there, and few visit it. It is quiet and isolated and lonely.

We would walk into the park and explore the headstones. Many dated over a hundred years ago. Obviously the settlers had a hard life. People died early. Many died before they hit their mid thirties. Many families had nearby rows of tombstones with the names of children that wouldn't live past three or four years of age. It was sad.

Sometimes we would find a family that would have maybe twelve or thirteen children's graves. Each one would hold a child that would be from one year old to four who had died. The mother, often would not make it past forty. Can you just imagine that life? Can you imagine the life that they must have had? Every year, getting pregnant. Having a baby, and every year, or every other year, having one of your children die. It must have been horrific and really debilitating.

Obviously the hard life, the harsh weather, the Indians and the illnesses took a toll. To survive they needed something. They needed God and spiritual guidance. I just cannot see how they would be able to keep on living without it.

The Tombstones

While many of the tombstones were simple (weather worn) sandstone affairs, there might be one or two large edifices. Sometimes these would be out of stone, but often they would

be cast out of zinc and looked to be in good condition. The zinc would be aged to a dark dull grey. These monuments looked good. They really did, with fine and crisp lines and decent appearance.

The stones, on the other hand, were worn pretty severely. Often you couldn't make out the words on the stones. Sometimes you couldn't even make out the shape of the stones themselves.

Those headstones made out of cast concrete tended to be in pretty good shape. They aged, but it was just dirty old concrete. Sometimes green moss would form on the folds in the cast headstone. However, aside from that, they looked pretty good.



It is very common to find headstones that look like trees. These do not typically seem to be carved out of stone. Instead, they appear to be cast out of concrete. It is a mystery to me as to what the limbs signified. This picture is typical and shows some moss and stains on the tombstone.

One of the common theme was large stone tombstones that resembled trees, with many limbs cut off. It is an interesting curiosity. One that I have yet to understand. I guess that for a time, it must have been a kind of fad. They date mostly to 1880s to 1920s, and are pretty unique.

- [Tree shaped tombstones let the dead speak](#)
- [Why are there carved tree headstones](#)

- [Why some gravestones are shaped like treestumps](#)
- [Tree-Stump style planters for headstones](#)

"The elaborately carved limestone markers were popular in the late 1800s through the 1920s, when they fell out of favor due to their expense, and contain symbols that speak volumes if you know what they're saying."

Clasped hands, if the sleeves are masculine and feminine, denote marriage, for example. Ferns are a symbol of frankness or humility; ivy can symbolize fidelity; and wheat represents the divine harvest.

[Many of the symbols](#) have dual religious and secular meanings, but in both cases they eternally memorialize the deceased's ideals and philosophies..."

[-Tree shaped tombstones let the dead speak](#)

I always found this an interesting consideration to ponder. I would go up to these tombstones and see different aspects of each one. One would just be a simple stump, like a tree that was wholly cut down. While others would represent a tree standing, but with broken limbs, sawed off limbs, and limbs mangled and distorted. The meaning of this was always a mystery to me.

"...many variations: the vertical stump, the double vertical stump, the horizontal stump, the ledger tree stump, the tree-stump bench, the tree-stump chair, the tree-stump cross, the simple tree-stump base. They could be decorated with birds, books, firearms, flowers, plants, anchors, or animals, along with the signs of fraternal orders, from unions to the Elks to the Freemasons.'

-Susanne Ridlen, in her 1999 book [Tree-Stump Tombstones](#).



Meshingomesia. A Miami Indian cemetery in Grant County Indiana. It is quite typical for the cemeteries in Indiana. It is isolated, quiet and lonely.

We would look at the names on the stones, the one's that we could read, that is. We would walk around the stones, and explore the nearby wooded area. As many of the few trees in North and Central Indiana were found only at the cemeteries. The rest of the land was wholly devoted to flat fields to grow crops.

Sometimes the cemeteries are completely overgrown. Here, huge trees would grow out of the remaining tombstones, and unless you looked and searched for the site, you would never be able to find it.

Sadly, a number of the cemeteries were converted to trash dumps by inconsiderate neighbors. The trees in the areas of the cemeteries that have become overgrown, became disused. Often, the groundskeeper would only mow or care for the "front" or visible portion of the cemetery and the rest would be permitted to lapse and revert to nature. Others, often uncaring, would dump trash there. Things such as old refrigerators, 1960's era baby strollers and old interior doors with the round brass or stone knobs would be found piled in heaps at the one end of the cemetery.

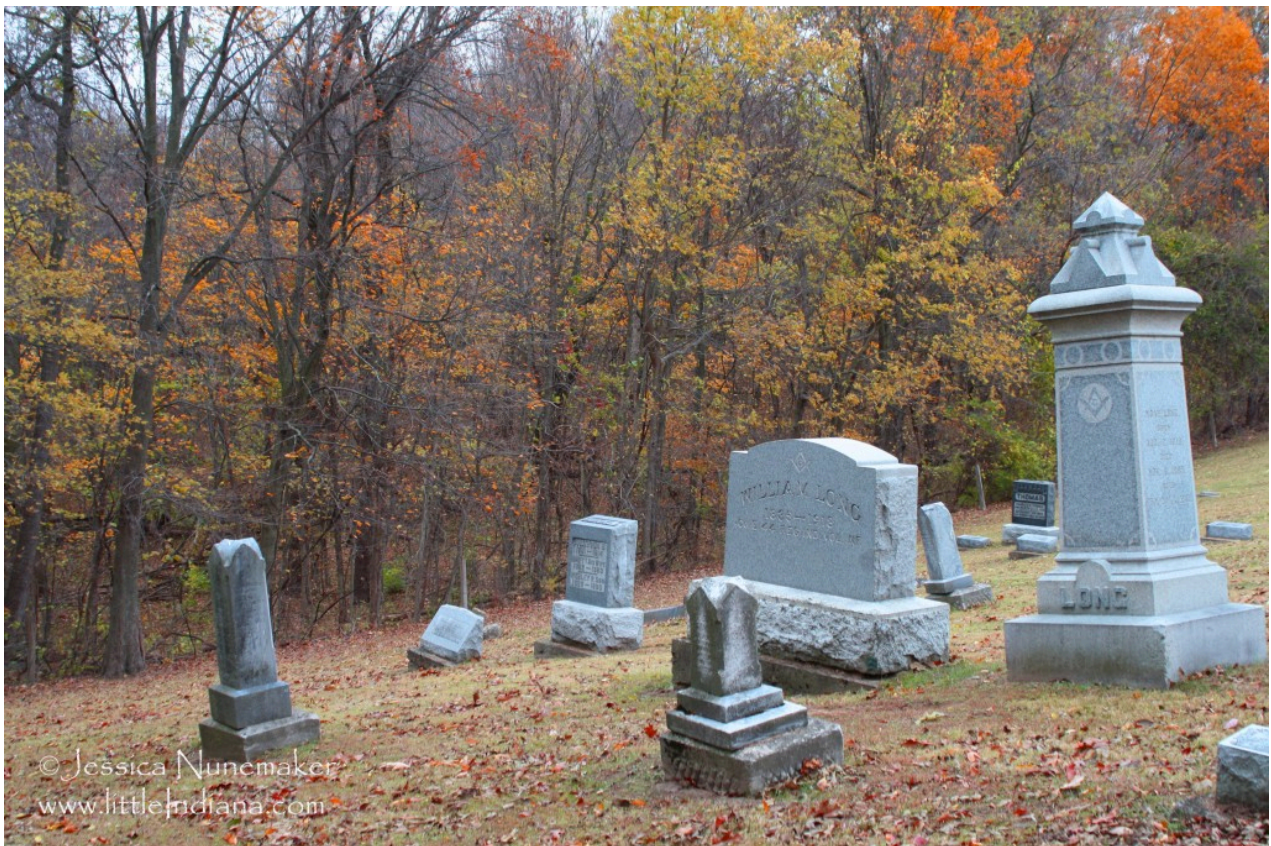
Curiosities

When a person would die and be buried, often the relatives would plant a tree, or a shrub near the grave. The thing is that these shrubs would be permitted to grow. What is often considered a small shrub, after a hundred years, becomes a worthwhile tree. These trees are magnificent and something that you will not see in or around any suburb because the tree takes far too long to mature. Heck, it's worth while just to go out and check out these magnificent tree-shrubs alone.

Another thing that is curious is the presence of ancient and aged plastic flowers. Sure they might have looked nice in 1970 when they were first placed on the grave, however time and decades have changed them into something else entirely different. Now they look like faded dirty plastic trash. Things that should have been discard along with smiling clown paintings, and vacuum tube AM band radios.

Where Built

Sometimes the cemeteries were built around an Indian mound. These mounds were part of the previous inhabitants of the area; "The Mound Builders". We would climb up on the mounds and survey the surrounding flatness. These mounds were huge and often had very steep sides. Most were excavated in the past, and often European settlers were buried inside the mound with tilted tombstones remaining on the sides like broken teeth.



Ball Hill cemetery located in Indiana. Sometimes the cemeteries were located on a hill. Indian is mostly flat, except in the southern section. Thus hills were a rare occurrence. The places were quiet and peaceful.

The Mysterious Blank Cemeteries

Many of these cemeteries were well mowed, perhaps once or twice a week. Aside from the groundskeepers, no one ever apparently visited these parks. Many did not seem to have any headstones.

It wasn't that the headstones were set flat to the earth. No. The headstones were missing all together completely. What was supposed to be a cemetery listed in the country map in the library seemed to be just a simple lawn of grass located in the middle of ample farmland.

They ended up looking like a flat space of a lawn at the edge of the rows of corn. Sometimes with a old fence around it. However, there were no headstones at all. This was a mystery, that is, until we went to the edge of the cemetery lot.



O'Neall cemetery in Indiana. Where are all the headstones? Why such great and wide lawns? If you go to the edge of the cemetery, near the tree line you will find a ditch. Look in the ditch. All the tombstones are there.

There, we would find many of the headstones randomly tossed into a ditch nearby. Apparently, over the years, the groundskeepers just pulled the headstones out to make it easier to mow the lawns. If a tree fell down, they would just remove the tree. It was too inconvenient to mow around it. They did not care.

They did not care.

No one checked on their work. So they would cut down the trees. They would remove the bushes, and then toss the headstones into a ditch or gully at the edge of the cemetery. No one noticed. No one cared. All that mattered is that the lowly paid groundskeeper had an easy job keeping the grass cut.

Which was, typically a young couple. Either doing so as a favor for the church, or being paid to do so by either a church or the country. Rarely would we ever see an “expert” groundskeeper maintaining these cemeteries. Oh, they do exist. Especially in the larger city cemeteries. I know, my uncle was one. However, in the smaller, rural cemeteries it was another story entirely. It was almost as if taking care of the cemeteries were an afterthought.



Bethel cemetery. Located in Richland Township in Steuben county Indiana. It is typical with trees on one end of the cemetery, but a total absence of trees near the tombstones so that the groundskeeper could mow the ground easily and simply.

There was no need for trees, bushes, shrubs or flowering plants. Any trees or plants grew in the ditches at the edge of the field, or alongside difficult to mow areas in the cemetery plots.

A Little History

Around a hundred and fifty years ago, people would go to the cemeteries to have “outings” and picnics. As such, they were maintained with visitors in mind. People would go to the local cemetery, layout a blanket, and eat cold cuts and maybe a pie and enjoy the day.

Massachusetts and the rest of New England lead the nation in this pastime.

In fact, I do urge the reader to go to their local libraries and look this long forgotten pastime up. I myself did not know about it until I visited the Milford, MA library and looked into the local cemeteries there.

Anyways, Indiana was founded by hardworking Germanic people, who rather frowned on leisure, and it is no wonder that the secondary use of cemeteries in Indiana was ignored

and forgotten. The people had a hard, tough life to live. They needed to focus. Over the years, their children became very pragmatic and concentrated on the things that mattered, and care for cemeteries and parks just simply became an afterthought.

Which, in my mind, is a real shame.

Ah. Indiana, what is [going on](#) with youse guys?

We are transient. Our physical existence is short lived. Make the [most](#) of it. Be the best that you can be. Enjoy life, and the people who surround you. For one day, they too will be gone.



About this picture. It's a cemetery in Milford Massachusetts. It is a beautiful cemetery, and right next to the Wendy's restaurant there.

Father Patrick Cuddihy came to Milford, MA in 1857 to head the St. Mary of the Assumption church. He directed the construction of a traditional Irish round tower to be built on church property in 1895. Now, these towers had been built in Ireland to help monks escape Vikings and other invaders. They were, for a time very popular and extremely useful. When the village or town was attacked, they would run to the tower and hide inside. They were accessed by ladders that were pulled up to prevent penetration by others.

Since then, the tower has become a landmark, and people come to the cemetery to chill out, rest during lunch and picnic there. The cemetery is well maintained, with enormous, big and beautiful trees. It has wonderful Massachusetts stones, and perfect areas of greenery.

While people drive their cars out to the cemetery for lunch today, it was once far more common a thing for people to participate in.

During the 19th century, and especially around the turn of the century, snacking in cemeteries happened all over the United States. It wasn't just apple-munching either. It was something else entirely. People would bring blankets and quilts to sit upon. they would carry baskets with cooked pies, baked chicken and sides of coleslaw. They would bring bottles of beer.

They would hang out. Listen to the birds. Play catch with a baseball, or maybe try to fly a kite. It was a place where you could go that was within nature and safe.

Since many municipalities lacked proper recreational areas, many people had full-blown picnics in their local cemeteries. The tombstone-laden fields were the closest things, then, to modern-day public parks. Instead of picnic tables, the families and couples would lay out a blanket on the grass beside a tombstone and enjoy a peaceful outing under the shady trees.

One of the reasons why eating in cemeteries become a "fad," was that epidemics were raging across the country. The reader must understand that diseases such as Yellow fever and cholera flourished. Often, children passed away before turning 10. Women died during childbirth. Death was a constant visitor for many families, and in cemeteries, people could "talk" and break bread with family and friends, both living and (figuratively) the deceased.



People used to go to cemeteries to have quiet and peaceful outings together. They would have picnics on blankets and enjoy each others company. The cemeteries were well maintained, shady, with nice lawns of grass, fragrant flowers and nice pathways.

Conclusions

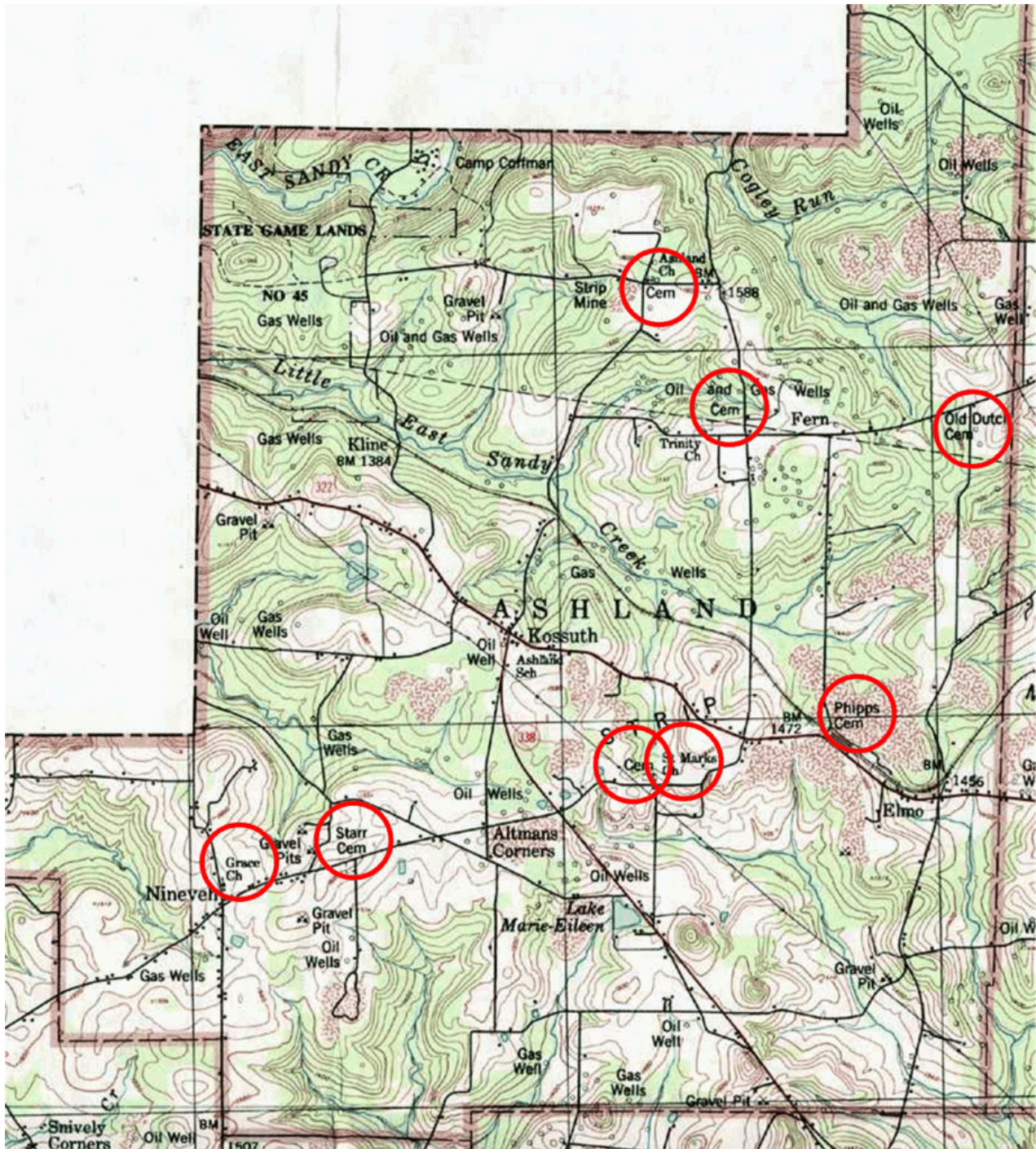
Cemeteries can teach us a lot about human nature and society. All we need to do is listen.

In the past, prior to investment in state parks and recreational facilities, cemeteries were used as local places to rest and relax. People enjoyed going out and relaxing in the shade of trees, enjoying the breeze and listening to the birds. Their homes, prior to air conditioning, were hot affairs, and people would hang out on the large porches and rest on “gliders” that would sway under the eaves.

Many smaller cemeteries are treated as afterthoughts. They are maintained cheaply and are viewed as a necessary labor that needs to be maintained, rather than an important part of society and culture.

Take Aways

- Exploring your county can be achieved by visiting all the cemeteries in it.
- To see where they are, go to the local library and look at the map there. It will list all of the cemeteries in your county.

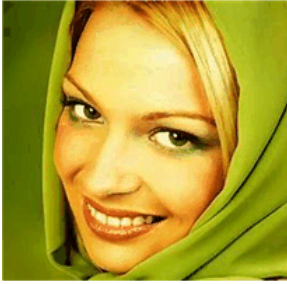


A map of your county will list all the cemeteries in it. The most comprehensive maps are found in the libraries in the county. Here, the cemeteries are highlighted in red. Map is a map of a random county.

- For us to appreciate where we are heading in the future, we need to have an appreciation of our past. A cemetery is a first step in this adventure.
- Cemeteries are not scary fear-filled places, but a soft place of rest and contentment.

Posts Regarding Life and Contentment

Here are some other similar posts on this venue. If you enjoyed this post, you might like these posts as well. These posts tend to discuss growing up in America. Often, I like to compare my life in America with the society within communist China. As there are some really stark differences between the two.



The Most Important Things That a Man Looks for in a Woman.

Here, we look at the things that men search for in a woman. These things are considered, by men, to be absolutely essential in a mate. We discuss ten attributes and go into detail as to why they are important.



What it was like being a kid in the early 1970's

This is my narrative of what it was like growing up as a young teenager in 1971. This took place in the hills of Pennsylvania outside of Pittsburgh. I was 13 years old. I went to school, rode my bicycle around everywhere. I fished with my father, and watched television a lot.



The Fiasco of the Reengineering of the Common Tomato

This is the sad, sad story about how the wonderful and tasty tomato was reengineered to be "better". It was made better to ship. Better to sell. Better to store. However, there was one thing missing. No one paid any attention to taste, which is why it tastes like a cardboard shipping box today.



A Movie Tribute to the 1980's When Ronald Reagan Ran

America. Here we argue that movies reflect society when they were made. Today we see popular movies being remade as all female versions due to the progressive realities today. Likewise, the movies of the 1980s reflected the time when they were made as well.



Mad Scientist Explorations

Here we discuss what it was like growing up as a boy in the 1960's and the 1970's and the people, things, and adventures that inspired us. As such, we explore how the independence of growing up enabled us to cope through life when we got older.



The Gorilla Cage in the Basement

When I was a small boy, I used to play in the abandoned buildings nearby. Here is a story about one of the objects that lay hidden inside one of those buildings and the possible mysteries that it held. As a child we thought it was a gorilla cage, now as an adult, I am not so sure...



The Importance of a Family Meal Together

There is nothing more important and satisfying than spending time together with friends and family and eating a meal together. It is a time of friendship, familial bonding and relaxation. Here we discuss what I have learned from my childhood and how I apply it today in my life.



The Pleasures of Fresh Baked Bread with Butter

One of the things that I have come to miss, since I moved to China, is fresh hard crusty rolls with full salted butter. The Chinese are not really fans of crusty bread. They like sweets and sponge cakes. Here I describe something that is close to me; not appreciating what you have right in front of you.



What Work was Like in the 1960's and 1970's.

When people go to work today, they find that there are all kinds of rules and regulations. It is for diversity, safety, inclusion, and improvement in a new progressive world. Well, here is what work was like before it became a sterile progressive testing ground for the New World Order.



Learning during my 1970s High School years

Here is a pretty long post on what it was like to go to elementary school in the 1960's, and then attend high school in the 1970's. I graduated in 1977, and that my friend is exactly the target date for the famous movie "Dazed and Confused". Here is the real deal what it was like.



Some True Stories of Cat Heaven

Being in MAJestic taught me many things. One of which was an intimate understanding of Heaven and other “spiritual” things relative to quanta entanglements. Here I discuss what it is like to have a beloved animal (cat) dies and what actually happens to them and why.



Life Lessons from Working within the Corporate Dream – 1

After I was trained by MAJestic, I was left to fend for myself in Corporate America. It was a hellish existence. As such, I learned many lessons concerning behavior and the ultimate impact that it holds on our families, our friends, our loved ones, and our very lives. Here are my commentaries.



Life Lessons from Working within the Corporate Dream – 2

This is part two of the two part section. There is quite a lot of information to impart. Stories are told, and experiences relayed. Honestly working in corporate America in the 1980's, through the new century really sucked. It was harsh on everyone except the owners of the companies.



How to Build Up Your Life from Nothing.

This is for all those young men who are just leaving school and trying hard to build up their life. You can do it. Here are my thoughts and advice for a young man who is encountering that most difficult of challenges; carving your life out in the wilds of the world.



Allow your Children to Play and Grow (Part 1)

I am horrified, just horrified, that parents do not allow their children to play, roam and explore on their own. It has created a society of pampered fearful children. Here I discuss this in terms of what I know. This is very non-PC and might offend the more liberal readers out there.



Allow your Children to Play and Grow (Part 2)

This is the second part of my rant about permitting children to play, explore and have fun. Everyone, the odds that some stranger will abduct your child is very small. Most people who do this are family friends and neighbors. Stop being so fearful. It harms the development of your child.



Ode to Diabolical Cretin John McCain

Well, that evil son-of-a-bitch is finally dead. If his grave wasn't so far away, I go there and dance on top of it. This guy has spent his life backstabbing people, hurting people, concocting wars, and doing everything in his power to disrupt the lives of people. Good fucking riddance.



The Song "Baby Got Back" Translated into Latin

Here is a fun post. The song "Baby Got Back" is translated into Latin and then back again. I have to tell you that it is indeed hilarious. *Rebecca, ecce! tantae clunes isti sunt!* (Rebecca, behold! Such large buttocks she has!) Anyways, it's just all fun and games. Enjoy.

More Posts about Life

I have broken apart some other posts. They can best be classified about ones actions as they contribute to happiness and life. They are a *little different*, in subtle ways.



On Being an Older Gent

Here are my thoughts on growing old as a man. The truth is that the life that I expected to have as I was growing up never materialized. Instead, something else manifested. My life today is nothing compared to what I thought it would be. For my illusions were created by American media.



Calexit and the American Civil War

This is a pretty detailed look at the causes of the American civil war, and why it wasn't about slavery. We look at the rewriting of history by the internet, and the efforts that President Obama took to keep California intact so that the Democrats could maintain political power and control.



Why an American man should leave America and Travel

All people should get up off their duff and go forth and Travel. However, this is most especially true for American men. The United States has become a crucible of PC progressive realities that attack and depreciate American men. Go out, young man, see the world as it really is!



The Amazing Bremelanotide PT-141

Forget Viagra, and all those other ED medications. This is the real deal. This little baby causes humans to *go into heat*. It interacts with the brain and sets up feelings of intense arousal on both men and women. It turns people into 16 year olds. As such it is banned in the USA by the FDA.



Bronco Billy and the 25th Law of Power

Bronco Billy is a fictional movie starring Clint Eastwood. The movie depicts the life of a man who decides to change his life and go ahead and do what he has always dreamed of doing. He goes out and becomes his dream. There are lessons here for all of us, we only need listen.



The r/K Selection Theory applied to American Politics

The r/K theory is a pretty well-known theory on animal behavior. It simply states that animals behave as they need to based on the scarcity of resources. Here, we argue that it can be applied to why humans follow different political philosophies. Especially in American politics.

 [How they get away with it](#)

 [Line in the sand](#)



The importance of having a second passport.

So President Trump is building a wall to protect Americans. Hum. Where have I heard that before? Oh yes, in Germany right when they were making the wall that separated Berlin. Walls serve two purposes; they keep people out, but they also keep people in. Be careful what you wish for.



How Rocket Scientists Build Paper Airplanes

This is a tale of what me and my classmates used to do when we were young Aerospace Engineering students at the university. We would design paper airplanes and shoot them down with bottle rockets. Here is just a fun little exercise down "memory lane". Enjoy.

 [Snopes](#)

 [Taxation without representation.](#)





Stories that Inspired Me

Here are reprints in full text of stories that inspired me, but that are nearly impossible to find in China. I place them here as sort of a personal library that I can use for inspiration. The reader is welcome to come and enjoy a read or two as well.





Articles & Links

- You can start **reading the articles** by going [HERE](#).
- You can visit the Index Page [HERE](#) to explore by article subject.

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Notes

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